

The biggest takeaway I had this week was the difference between weak and strong problem framing. The slide that says “food waste is bad” to a thoughtful HMW statement made me realize that my first description for my stock analysis app was weak too. I kept thinking “how might we build a portfolio tracker” instead of starting from the actual user need. The 5 whys helped me get past this and get to a real HMW statement: how might we help investors track their portfolios and make confident decisions without needing financial expertise. When I went through the checklist, I caught myself embedding a solution in my first draft which the slides flagged as a red flag pattern. Rewriting it to focus on the user's need instead of the technology made the whole project feel more grounded, and it changed how I approached the value proposition work later in the week. The hardest part for me was not going straight to features. When I used AI for user personas, I noticed a pattern that this week’s slides warned me about. Assuming what different user segments wanted instead of testing it. Seeing how differently a retiree persona and a beginner investor persona reacted to the same pitch was a useful check on my own assumptions, even though I know AI personas only go so far as a substitute for real feedback. I used Claude this week to draft AI personas and simulate interviews for my value proposition testing assignment. It helped me quickly test my HMW statement and value proposition against four different user types, which would have taken much longer to do with real interviews at this stage. I changed Claude's first draft of the cautious retiree persona because it assumed she'd be won over just by simple language, but I thought this might just be a stereotype within the AI. Therefore, I flagged it as an insight to verify with a real person in Week 5 rather than taking it at face value.